

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1979-05-08

To an individual Bahá'í

Dear Bahá'í Friend,

impressed with the eager desire you show to train your behavior in accordance with the standards of the Faith. It has asked us to send you the following comments in answer to your questions. 321224.2 On page 25 of *The Advent of Divine Justice* the beloved Guardian is describing the requirements not only of chastity, but of “a chaste and holy life”—both the adjectives are important. One of the signs of a decadent society, a sign which is very evident in the world today, is an almost frenetic devotion to pleasure and diversion, an insatiable thirst for amusement, a fanatical devotion to games and sport, a reluctance to treat any matter seriously, and a scornful, derisory attitude towards virtue and solid worth. Abandonment of “a frivolous conduct” does not imply that a Bahá'í must be sour-faced or perpetually solemn. Humor, happiness, joy are characteristics of a true Bahá'í life. Frivolity palls and eventually leads to boredom and emptiness, but true happiness and joy and humor that are parts of a balanced life that includes serious thought, compassion and humble servitude to God are characteristics that enrich life and add to its radiance.

224.3 Shoghi Effendi's choice of words was always significant, and each one is important in understanding his guidance. In this particular passage, he does not forbid “trivial” pleasures, but he does warn against “excessive attachment” to them and indicates that they can often be “misdirected.” One is reminded of 'Abdu'l-Bahá's caution that we should not let a pastime become a waste of time.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]